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A REFERENCE DOCUMENT • TOWARD A BOOK

The Five Respects

Mapped in the spirit of C.S. Lewis's The Four Loves — five distinct flavors of respect, and the philosophy that produces them

“But why? Really — but why?”

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I

The Core Thesis

Begin with the tone, because the tone is the argument: *but why?* Not cynically — curiously. The whole of this document should be read with genuine curiosity as its keynote. Because what I have noticed is deceptively simple: in life, we are almost never given transparency about our perceived developmental stage.

We are each balancing many accounts at once — not only financial, but social, and accounts of scope: our understanding of the world, our skill sets, our grasp of industries and of the economy, our reach into the academic and the platonic and the philosophical, our sense of what it means to mature into a broader understanding of society, and of what it means to be true to one's own nature. Being true to your nature is a load-bearing idea here. So is that other, more radical one — *love thy enemy* — which both Marcus Aurelius and Jesus insist upon. It is not merely a concept but a behavior and a practice, and a genuinely radical one.

THE THESIS

Communicating a perception of another's developmental stage creates a power dynamic that is not respectful.

With age you begin to feel the underlying reason we do *not* broadcast how we perceive one another's development across the many accounts of a life. Part of it is wisdom: it isn't worth it; you would rather be liked than be right; you stop trying to correct every perceived deficiency you notice. And there is a corollary worth stating plainly — **when you're getting flack, you're on the mark.** People do not have infinite energy to give. They will not spend it on everyone they meet.

II

Developmental Stage & the Absence of Transparency

Consider the neighborhood watch. The neighbors do not walk over to Jim and say, *if you took care of your lawn, we'd invite you into the watch*. Everyone else's lawn is kept; Jim's is not; he is not showing pride of ownership — and no one tells him why he isn't being included in the decision-making. Or consider a child: you may not fold a child into paying the family's taxes, because you perceive them to be at a different developmental stage, unable to hold that scope. People grasp this instinctively.

But society has become hyper-communicative — internet, media, all of it — and so we arrive at a matrix of educated and uneducated, in-group and out-group. Those who believe themselves in-group and educated tend to treat every other quadrant as occupying a lesser developmental stage. **Public health is the cleanest example:** the message is declared true and good for *this* group but not that one, wholesome for the in-group but requiring a different, softened version for the out-group. That is truth being warped.

THE FAULT LINE OF HUMAN TRUTH

The warping originates in something tender: our empathy for the parent — and especially the mother — who has passed through that second puberty of raising children, and who has learned to meet a child at its stage with a fitting tone. Turned outward onto other adults, that same instinct becomes a kind of toxic empathy: the belief that truth must be softened for those outside your in-group or below your education level. It runs across every account of a life.

III

The Openness Matrix

Here is a simple lens. Arrange the persons of grammar into a matrix — *I, you, he/she/it, we, y'all, they* (first, second, third; singular then plural). Openness is an *arc* drawn across this field. Where the arc favors the top-left, most of the field is green — *I, you, we* are good, and only a small wedge of *they* at the bottom-right reads as bad. Low openness inverts it: even parts of *I* and *you* and *we* read as bad, and *he/she/it, y'all, they* are almost wholly bad. It is, in short, a gradient of how open you are to the stranger.

1ST SING. I	2ND SING. You	3RD SING. He / She / It
1ST PLUR. We	2ND PLUR. Y'all	3RD PLUR. They

↖ high openness — the arc spares most of the field (green)

↘ low openness — the arc condemns nearly all but the self (red)

The openness gradient across the persons of grammar. Green is “good / admitted”; red is “bad / suspect.”

Openness is the arc that decides how much of the stranger you let into the green.

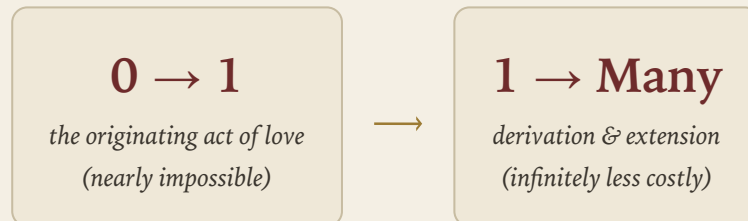
IV

Xenia — 0→1 and 1→Many

This matters because of *xenia* — Zeus's law, as the Nolan *Odyssey* frames it — the sacred entertaining of the stranger. To welcome the stranger is the radical move; it is either another instance of 1→many, or perhaps itself a 0→1.

Here is the distinction. Going from **0** to **1** in love is very nearly impossible; Jesus is the epitome of that first, originating act. Going from **1** to **many** — de-

iving, extending, applying what already exists once — is almost infinitely easier by comparison. Which is exactly what makes Marcus Aurelius so astonishing: reading the *Meditations*, you realize he reached so many of the 1→many points *without* the 0→1 in front of him. Perhaps xenia — entertaining the stranger — was his own 0→1, the seed from which so much of stoicism's complexity grew. I hold both in deep respect: the parables and teachings of Jesus, and the meditations of Marcus Aurelius.



The asymmetry of love. Jesus as the 0→1; Marcus Aurelius reaching the 1→many without it.

V

What Gets You Into Pursuit

By John Locke's definition, the pursuit of happiness is the pursuit of that which you pursue — pleasingly circular. So the better question is: *what puts you into a state of pursuit?* There are three valid answers, and being true to your nature means honoring whichever is yours.

THE FEMININE

Passion

The pull that ignites the chase.

THE NEUTRAL

Balance

The equilibrium that sustains.

THE MASCULINE

Solvency

In the Austen sense — the ground to stand on.

Passion, Solvency, Balance — the three answers to “what gets you into pursuit?” All three are valid; the point is to be true to your own.

Developing a relationship with another person begins, of all things, in **play**. The games grow more sophisticated as we age, but we are still, always, looking for people to play with. As you play, you learn people's boundaries as they express their needs and their values; needs and values express boundaries; boundaries teach you how to speak to someone. That is the foundation of *the language of their respect*.

WHY THIS BOOK IS NOT YET COMPLETE

Alongside the Five Respects there must be a companion set — the *languages of respect* — and I cannot yet isolate them into a finite list. They surface in the common patterns among the needs and values people express, and they are not identical for everyone. That part I am still learning, and you can infer some of it as we go.

VI

Defining the Good

In a physical, literal sense, the good here is **pro-social, cooperative behavior that encourages transaction by maintaining morale**. Part of that requires the management of libido — libido sublimated into pro-social, cooperative, communicative behavior. That is the good.

Its essential companion: **independence is not maturity; interdependence is maturity**. And here is the fault line that Marcus Aurelius and Jesus hold in common — they emphasize the *independence* within interdependence. Much of society emphasizes the *dependence* within it, and does so by insisting *you are not sufficient without us* — not without their products, not without their services. That manufactured insufficiency extracts value by keeping you in a state of consumption, anger, and lust. Retail spaces cultivate it deliberately: *see* → *desire* → *take* feedback loops (which ties back to solvency, and to what a society collectively decides it desires).



The see–desire–take loop cultivated by environments of manufactured insufficiency. The alternative is self-governance.

VII

Self-Governance & the Fabric of Solidarity

The antidote to that loop is self-governance: not lunging, not seizing what we desire. And self-governance is held together by something I can only call the **fabric of solidarity** — a material, a honey of a certain viscosity. In peacetime that honey is thick enough to keep us from breaking social norms; we self-

govern almost without noticing. In wartime the viscosity fails. The fabric we take for granted in peace is lost. Which is precisely where the rest of the philosophy has to interface.

VIII

Freedom as Chosen Debt

From *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* comes the image I keep returning to. Two old women live miles apart. One brings the other a cup of sugar. The other walks the miles back and returns only *half* a cup — “*I guess I'll have to come back tomorrow.*” Had she returned a full cup, the first woman might well ask: *why don't you want to be in debt to me? Don't you want to have to walk back?*

FREEDOM, DEFINED

Freedom is choosing with whom you are in debt — choosing to whom you are beholden.

IX

A Little Predicate Calculus

Some of the load-bearing structure is cleaner stated as logic.

THE PARENTAL PAIR

Necessity $\longrightarrow$ Invention

Responsibility $\longrightarrow$ Accomplishment

If necessity is the mother of invention, then responsibility is the father of accomplishment.

OPTIONALITY AND LOYALTY ARE BICONDITIONAL

Optionality $\Longleftrightarrow$ Loyalty

Neither is real without the other. Loyalty with no options is bending the knee to a king who never moves. Optionality that can never commit — never collapse — is not real optionality at all; its prospect-theoretic wavefunction never resolves into anything anyone can depend on. (From the prior book, Put Options on Loyalty.)

CHOICE PRESUPPOSES ORDER

Axiom of Choice $\Longleftrightarrow$ Well-Ordered Set

*Order is a precondition of choice — which is exactly why freedom of religion is numbered **first**.*

Chain the conditionals and they terminate in **purpose**: passion, solvency, and balance alleviate bare necessity; we aim not merely to survive but to survive with *vitality*; vitality comes from the optionality that passion, solvency, and balance produce; and when self-governance is paired with self-imposed responsibility, freedom — choosing with whom you're in debt — becomes the choosing of your own responsibilities. That is how you get purpose.



X

The Five Respects

With that long chain of conditionals landing on purpose, we can finally differentiate the five. Each is a genuinely distinct *flavor*, not a matter of degree.

THE FIRST RESPECT

Man → Man

Rooted in the hunt. There is a component of manhood tied to reward: the mind has to pay itself to go hunt — risk spikes dopamine; a successful hunt delivers the serotonin. A man needs to take risk to differentiate fully into manhood. He toils in the dust for his daily bread (Genesis), appropriating resources into the household. That is his role, and it is well fit to his nature.

THE SECOND RESPECT

Man → Woman

A different flavor entirely. The feminine differentiation is not the taking-on of risk; a woman is fully differentiated in *managing with* the household's resources — and in feeling the pain of her children, in childbirth and across a life. These are distinct roles, and they must be distinct. A rite of passage for a man is learning that a woman wants a *different kind* of respect — nowhere clearer than in the copulation dynamic (as Orion Taraban's *The Value of Others* would put it, no woman finishes by thanking you for respecting her *so hard*). This is where the New Testament's asymmetric command — *men, love your wives; women, respect your husbands* — is not my premise but my *derivation*: a fruiting body from the mycelium of everything above.

Man → Animal

The one I understand least, and so I let it sit near the end, honestly unfinished. I would want to talk to a farmer — about raising a pig in the household for years, then taking it to slaughter, then eating it. I don't yet grasp that respect. But I have fragments. My cousin's two dogs in Kentucky, outside dogs on an acre, riding the truck bed — when both leaned to one side he knew there was a turkey; they'd leap out and take it. The happiest dogs I've ever seen, because they were true to their nature. The indigenous intuition (Zach Bush, via Joe Rogan) that the gazelle in some sense *chooses* its moment with the lion — that prey is not simply victim. The fly that flew from my hand yet sat perfectly still as a lizard walked up and ate it. Something in the predator-prey model (Lotka-Volterra: more sharks, fewer minnows; fewer minnows, fewer sharks; and around) — and in morale models, active and passive — is the substance of this respect. (*Include the epidemiological case: in STD spread, transmission runs to the passive partner; when both partners switch between active and passive roles, the disease propagates through the community — a morale model the CDC uses for the spread of AIDS.*) Even the oldest war on earth — bacteria against fungus — belongs here; and so does the odd thought that college students educate their biomes and carry them home to kiss grandma, as if we were driven by our microbiomes toward some deeper, mutual purpose we don't yet see.

Man → God

Best entered through *fear and awe* — Yosemite, where I felt both. Fear and awe are the critical components of the respect for God, and for the unknown forces. The insurance industry has always kept a category for *acts of God* — the tsunami, the hurricane. My claim: **what was once an act of God may cease to be one, but there will always be acts of God**, because it costs too much time and too many resources to model what we call random. Slow the video and a machine could flip a coin identically forever; randomness is often just modeling that is too expensive to afford. That is a piece of respecting God. It is also uncomfortably conducive to a surveillance age: to have spent generations believing an objective eye witnesses everything is now literally substantiated — heart rates, eye movement, biometrics, intentions, negligences, the staking of whether you'll repay your debt, and your demographic proxies representing you even when you are “off the grid.” I believe in the freedom of religion; salvation is one's own responsibility. Out of that optionality I choose Christianity and stoicism — with the modern privilege of Frankensteining together the ancient word from many texts and epic poetries, to hear the currents that run deep in human and societal nature. There are macro-synapses and micro-synapses in this cosmic mind of intricate design — the Strait of Hormuz, the Silk Road — and the respect is for the multidimensional, fractal intricacy from the micro to the macro.

Man → Authority

The order matters. The First Amendment is *one*: 1.1 freedom of religion, 1.2 freedom of speech, 1.3 freedom to assemble and air grievances. Religion is first because the axiom of choice is biconditional with the well-ordered set. Groups develop through stages of play — **free play** → **instrumental play** → **deliberative play** — and Robert's Rules encode the majority-rule of deliberative assemblies. So ask, in the keynote tone: *but why* would authority be incentivized to keep people from assembling and airing grievances — to plant divisive symbols, to intercede when free play turns instrumental so it never turns deliberative? Why would a king of England, moved by St. Augustine, introduce Christianity — a faith that incentivizes martyrdom and teaches that we are sufficient, sovereign, that God is within us and needs no authority to broker the relationship? Respect for authority is real, but it is *not natural* to treat authority as equivalent to God. These are fellow people — men, women, animals; wise, foolish, wicked — following standards and protocols, holding a monopoly on legitimate violence. That last fact, met with self-governance and self-reflection, creates the power dynamic. Note the callback: had you already self-governed and agreed to those constraints within any of the other four relationships, you would not *inherently* owe authority this respect — with the caveat that runs through Man→God: it is a genuinely different flavor to respect the godliness in authority than to respect it in God. And the thesis ripples through here too: authority will never tell you its perception of your developmental stage, within accounts it does not even profess to be keeping.

1

Freedom of religion — first, because order precedes choice

2

Freedom of speech — enabled once the first is in place

3

Freedom to assemble & air grievances — the deliberative
end of play

*The well-ordered set of the First Amendment. Groups move: free play → instrumental play →
deliberative play.*

XI

Coda

So the thesis returns to close the circle: **communicating a perception of another's developmental stage creates a power dynamic that is not respectful** — which is why life so rarely hands you the transparency you crave about your own standing. Wisdom, in Proverbs, begins in the fear of God and grows by seeking understanding; the foolish hold understanding loosely; the wicked pose false KPIs to bend others toward their own aims. Between those, we are not static but dynamic. Man→Man, Man→Woman, Man→Animal, Man→God, Man→Authority — five distinct flavors of the same underlying material. The rest I will keep learning. For now: *but why?* Keep asking.

The Five Respects — a living reference document toward a future book.

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